KEY TAKEAWAYS

- As shorter formats of the game are heavily tilted towards batters, offer something to the bowlers in Test cricket to keep the spectators engaged with the longer format
- The current format of ODIs has become monotonous. To make it exciting, there should be four sessions of 25 overs each with both teams playing alternately
- There's need to strike a fair balance between bowlers and batters. Allow an extra fielder outside the ring in ODIs and withdraw the ban on using saliva to shine the ball
- The women players in India have arrived. They have the infrastructure and platform to showcase their talent. The results will follow soon
- Sachin has a photographic memory when it comes to his 781 international innings, and can recount his mode of dismissal in any of them in a jiffy



If a Test match does not last for five days but the cricket is exciting, that's what matters and that's what is going to keep cricket alive

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Whenever I have a cricket bat in my hand, it should be serious business. It should not be for fun... Whenever you are representing India, nothing should be taken for granted

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ODIs are getting monotonous without any doubt... The current format, I feel, is heavy on the bowlers

within three days (due to bowler-friendly wickets) is nothing to fret over, Sachin said keeping the game exciting and the spectators captivated is what really matters. And to keep the game exciting, he had a few suggestions up his sleeve. Like the need to rethink the ban on the use of saliva to shine the ball, which was imposed during the Covid-19 pandemic. Starting with a caveat ("I am no medical expert first of all"), Sachin explained how its use had helped swing bowlers for over 100 years and why it needs to come back.

But if his analysis of the game was insightful and thought-provoking, as expected from the 'God of Cricket', everyone was in for a surprise when Sachin showcased his photographic memory. When quizzed about his various dismissals, Sachin not only recalled correctly how he got out—for instance, caught behind on Ian Botham's bowling in the 1992 World Cup tie against England—but also how he felt at the time ("I didn't particularly enjoy that reaction after Botham got me out; so a little bit fire inside"). And the icing on the cake came when, with a bat in his hands, 'The Master Blaster' replicated his epic upper cut for a six off Shoaib Akhtar's bowling in the 2003 World Cup. ■